

CAR SEVA

A roadside chat while at a stop in Neem ka Thana left ex-Rajasthan CM **Ashok Gehlot** chuckling. Young dhaba owner Shambhu Dayal Saini suggested he trade in his white Tata Safari, a loyal companion of 15 years, for a Land Rover Defender. "Leaders change cars often these days, everyone's into Defenders now," Saini opined. Gehlot, momentarily puzzled, asked, "What's a Defender?" When he got the drift, he broke into a laugh, saying: "Old is gold."

PLUG THE LEAK



Patidar quota stir face and later BJP MLA **Hardik Patel** is in the news for threatening an agitation over the "leaky infrastructure" in his Viramgam constituency. Since joining the saffron side, Hardik had been reduced to just another face among the BJP's 156 MLAs, often mocked for losing his bite. The protest call, though, has stirred local officials into action, more because urban body polls are near and the party is scrambling to save face with complaints aplenty.

DYNASTIC DRIFT



Bharat Rashtra Samithi leader **K. Kavitha** launched a hunger strike in Hyderabad on August 4, demanding 42 per cent reservation for the Backward Classes, but the action hasn't gone down well in her own party. BRS insiders are calling it a "solo act", yet another sign of Kavitha's growing isolation. Meanwhile, father, ex-CM and party chief K. Chandrashekar Rao, under fire over irregularities in the Kaleshwaram Lift Scheme, seems unable to rein in the rebellion.

Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Rohit Parihar, Jumana Shah and Amarnath K. Menon

SCIENCE WATCH

By **Amarnath K. Menon**

THE R&D DEFICIT
WHERE ARE THE SCIENTISTS?

Nobel laureates and physicists Duncan Haldane and David Gross have just pointed out a huge mismatch: India has the talent, but is not benefitting because there's not enough funds for scientific research. Speaking at the Quantum India Summit in Bengaluru on July 31, Gross, who chairs an advisory board at the International Centre for Theoretical Sciences here, says India 's lack of investment in R&D doesn't bode well.

India's GDP is up, but its contribution to 'investments to the future', which will drive new technologies and industries, is low. In 2009, India's R&D spend was 0.84 per cent of GDP; it fell to 0.64 per cent by 2021 and is estimated to be 0.7 per cent in 2025. This is much less than what the US (3.5 per cent) and China (2.4 per cent) spends.

The Rs 1 lakh crore Research Development and Innovation (RDI) fund, announced in this year's budget, should help. It will be operationalised this year, with Rs 20,000 crore already allocated. The Anusandhan National Research Foundation, launched last year, also has a fund, but will primarily invest in academic research and research labs. The RDI fund is meant for private sector R&D, with its Deep Tech Fund 1.0 focusing on strategic autonomy in critical sectors like clean energy and advanced materials.

Last year, India was ranked 39th in the Global Innovation Index of 133 countries, up one spot from 2023. The number of full-time equivalent (FTE) researchers per million people in India is 255, abysmal when compared to the USA (4,452), China



SHUTTERSTOCK

(1,307), Korea (7,980), and far below the global average of 1,198. The trend of fewer FTE researchers and minimal spends points to an underlying crisis in the R&D sector. As one researcher at the summit put it: "Cutting-edge research is so fast; if we lose the first few years [due to cost-cutting], we are behind our colleagues abroad already." ■